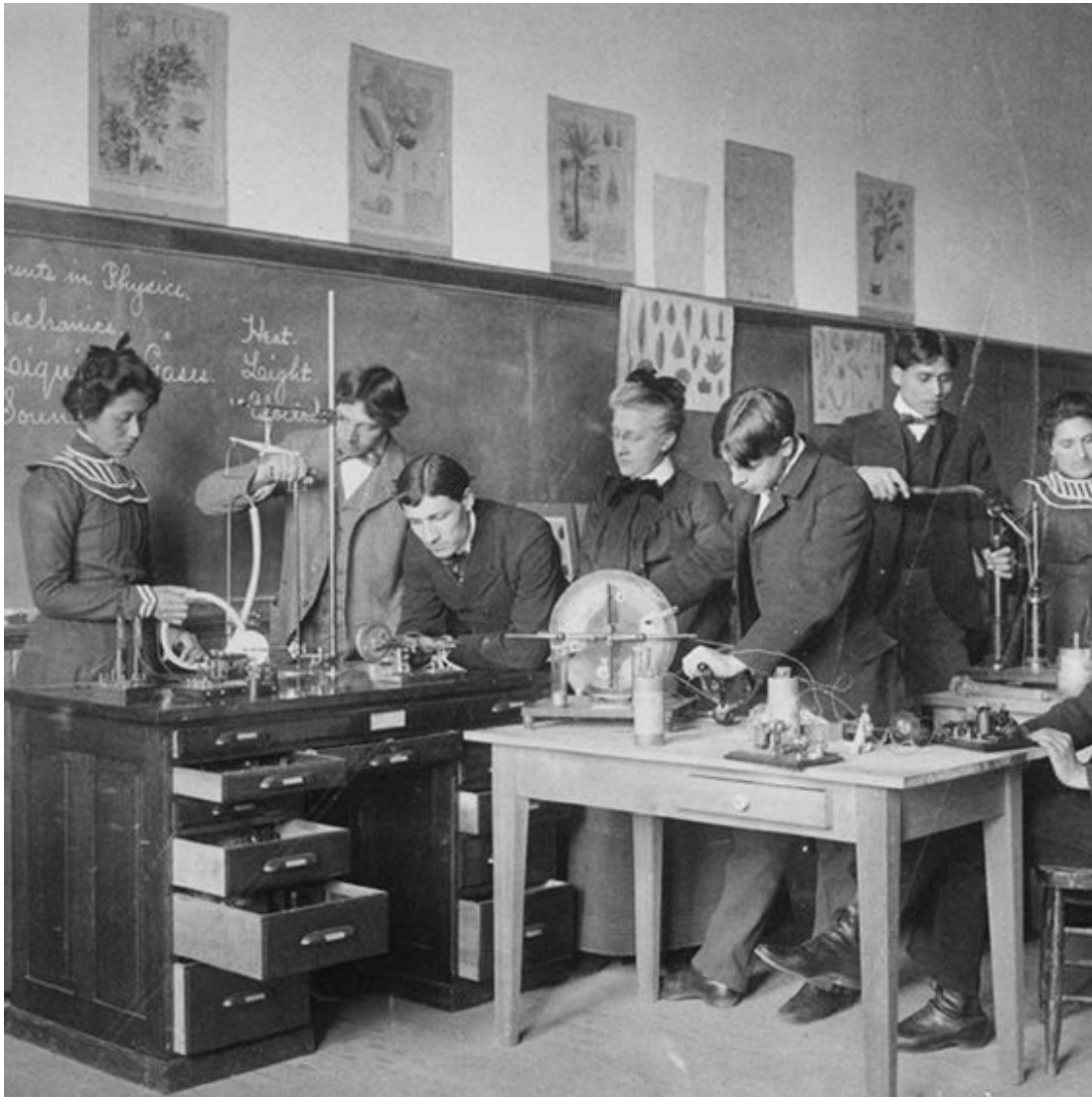


Positivism



While empiricism developed primarily in Britain to rival continental rationalism, a small but influential movement based on the principles of scientific method also emerged in France. The central idea of this movement, positivism, was that the only valid knowledge is that which can be positively verified, so truth can only be found in scientific knowledge.

The leading figure of the positivists was Auguste Comte, who felt that metaphysical speculation should no longer play a part in philosophy, and should be replaced by scientific enquiry. Breaking with the continental

tradition of rationalism, he advocated the empirical process of observation, theory formation and verification to establish knowledge of the world. Positivism was a symptom of the slowly widening division between science and philosophy, but Comte is also considered a pioneer in the modern philosophy of science (see [Philosophy and science in the 20th century](#)), the branch of philosophy that examines the foundations and methods of science, and its wider implications.